Step 0: Pre-analysis Reflexive Declaration

- **Home grammar:** My predisposition is closest to a liberal internationalist / democracy-promoting grammar. I tend to view security through the lens of values like human rights and democratic governance, and I suspect I will be most comfortable using signals (e.g. WMD evidence, civilian suffering, reconstruction outcomes) in those terms.
- **Hardest grammar:** I expect it will be hardest to operate the neoconservative/security grammar faithfully, because it prioritises national security threats and state power in a way that conflicts with my inclination to weigh normative and humanitarian factors. The anti-war/critical grammar may also be challenging if I find it too negative or one-sided in practice.
- **Blind spots:** From a liberal-democratic viewpoint, I might under-emphasise legitimate security concerns or the perspective that the Iraqi regime itself posed a threat. I might miss arguments about Iraq as a geopolitical locus of great-power competition. Conversely, a critical grammar might underplay any positive developments.
- **Temporal orientation:** I am naturally backward-looking and causal-historical (explaining how past causes led to present results). I expect to focus on causation and hindsight assessment, rather than forward-looking prescriptions.

Section 1: Observation Field Declaration

Phenomenon: The 2003 US-led invasion of Iraq and its aftermath, from the late-2002 war build-up through the occupation, insurgency, and up to present-day (2026) regional situation.

Temporal frame: 2002–2026. This spans the pre-war intelligence phase, major combat (2003), occupation years (2003–2011), the insurgency/sectarian war (2003–2011), rise of ISIS (2013–2017) and its defeat, up to current assessments.

Geographic scope: Primarily Iraq, but with attention to regional impacts (Syria, Iran, neighboring states, global geopolitics).

Why interpretive divergence arises: The Iraq case was politically and ideologically charged from the start. Different communities (e.g. US neoconservatives, liberal interventionists, isolationists, Arab nationalists, anti-imperialists, sectarian groups) attended to very different factors. Signals like WMD intelligence, civilian suffering, and reconstruction outcomes could be read as vindication (the threat was real and removed) or as indictment (false intelligence, needless killing, failed rebuilding). The same data thus sustains opposite narratives.

Signal contestation level: Highly contested domain. Many core "signals" (e.g. casualty figures, WMD evidence) were disputed across interpretive communities. For instance, claims of Iraqi WMD were vigorously contested; casualty counts had wide uncertainty and politicization

. In some cases, even what counts as a valid signal (e.g. insurgent vs sectarian violence) differs by grammar, suggesting ontological divergence.

Major interpretive communities (grammars): At least three salient camps stand out:

- **Security realist / neoconservatives:** Emphasize *threat* (WMD, terrorism), national interest, regime threat; likely to justify intervention.
- **Liberal democratists:** Emphasize *democracy & human rights*, regime change, humanitarian aspects; supportive of ousting Saddam though often critical of implementation.

- **Critical/anti-imperialist:** Emphasize *imperial motives* (oil, power), illegality, human costs; generally see the war as unjustified and disastrous.

Additional voices (e.g. Iraqi sectarian perspectives, Islamist, Baathist nostalgia) also differ, but for tractability we focus on three broad grammars (above), acknowledging that internal dissent exists (e.g. moderate Iraqis who welcomed Saddam's fall).

Section 2: Signal Set

We identify core signals (empirical inputs), noting their source/type and ambiguity. Each is phrased neutrally; later grammars will weight them differently.

- **Pre-war WMD Intelligence (qualitative):** U.S. 2002 National Intelligence Estimate claimed Iraq "had chemical and biological weapons, and is restarting nuclear efforts"

; Lancet survey ~650k excess deaths (to 2006); Costs-of-War ~268k–295k (2003–2018) (World Bank: "unprecedented" budget . Unemployment remained high; many projects failed (e.g. collapsing electricity grids). Source: WB report, audits ; spillover to Syria helped fuel civil war. Source: UNHCR/CRS

- . Ongoing issues: corruption, militia influence, slow reforms. Source: SIPRI 2023, UN/IMF reports. Ambiguity: "Stable" relative term; many say enduring problems remain.

Counter-signals (contradictory evidence):

- *WMD signals vs Duelfer:* The lack of post-war WMD (Duelfer) directly contradicts the pre-war threat narrative
- .
- *Cost vs Benefit:* High US/expenditure and casualties conflict with claims of quick victory or high ROI.
- *Refugees vs Democracy:* Massive displacement and sectarian bloodshed undermine messages of "liberation" and nation-building success.
- *Local Agency:* Popular Iraqi elections (2005–present) and civil society improvements challenge views that the war only caused chaos.
  These will be handled within each grammar's logic rather than segregated at end.

Contested signals: Some data are "grammar-dependent": e.g.

- *Casualty Attribution:* A death in 2006 might be counted as "insurgent violence" by one grammar or "sectarian cleansing" by another.
- *ISIS vs al-Qaeda:* Some may count early insurgents as part of ISIS threat continuum (proposing war legacy), others see ISIS as a distinct later phenomenon.
- We will flag such contestation explicitly below when relevant.

Section 3: Grammar Specifications

We define three interpretive grammars, each with required parameters (A–E) and recommended ones (F–H). For clarity we label them but note these are analytical constructs:

Grammar 1: Security-Realist / Neoconservative Grammar

- **Primary variable (A):** Perceived *threat to national/regional security*. War prevention and regime-neutralization of threats (especially WMD/terrorism) are seen as fundamental.

- **Signal selection (B):** Prioritize intelligence and strategic signals: WMD indicators, military capacity, terrorist links. Emphasize signals that support an imminent threat narrative (e.g. missile sites, Al Qaeda contacts, failed inspections). Deemphasize long-term indicators like civil society or oil control if not directly tied to threat.
- **Weighting priority (C):** Highest weight to signals of imminent danger (e.g. Cheney's "Saddam has WMD" claim
-). Then military outcomes (e.g. quick toppling of Saddam as validation) and sectarian stability (low post-war Sunni revolt). Lower weight to reconstruction outcomes or human cost, except insofar as they justify further action.
- **Causal chain type (D):** Linear threat-disruption logic: e.g. "Iraq has WMD (signal) ⇒ Saddam a threat ⇒ war needed ⇒ Saddam ousted ⇒ threat eliminated ⇒ greater security." The cause-effect is directional (threat ⇒ war).
- **Admissible closure (E):** Conclusions are usually in support of war's rationale. Permits outcomes like "war was necessary and largely successful," including qualified success if some problems arose. Disallowed conclusions: that war was wholly unjustified or disastrous; at worst war had errors, but necessity was real.
- **Excluded signals (F):** Signals not directly tied to threat: e.g. Iraqi public opinion (unless hostile to US), or pre-war UN condemnation (unless turned to WMD story). Economic motives (oil) are often excluded or downplayed.
- **Characteristic vocabulary (G):** Terms like "threat," "intelligence," "regime," "compliance," "Saddam," "al-Qaida," "axis of evil," "war on terror," "coalition victory."
- **Temporal orientation (H):** Primarily backward-causal (justifying the past decision) but forward-prescriptive when needed ("lessons learned for future threats"). Emphasis is on immediate causation (why war *had* to happen) and strategic necessity, not on long-term social meaning.

Grammar boundary: It would become Grammar 2 if its primary variable shifted to *democratic governance* (e.g. from focus on threat to focus on political outcomes) or Grammar 3 if focus shifted to *economic motives* or *imperial consequences*.

Source tradition: Think tanks and policymakers of 2000s US security establishment: e.g. PNAC writings, Pentagon reports, Richard Cheney speeches

, and conservative media (e.g. Wall Street Journal editorials).

Grammar 2: Liberal-Democratic / Humanitarian Grammar

- **Primary variable (A):** *Democratization and human rights*. The emphasis is on whether the war and occupation advance freedom, self-governance, and humanitarian goals.
- **Signal selection (B):** Focus on signals related to governance and human welfare: e.g. establishment of elections, women's rights, decline of tyranny. Admit WMD intelligence if it relates to justification for regime change, but also give weight to post-war democratic indicators (elections in 2005/10/14, Iraqi civil society).
- **Weighting priority (C):** Highest weight to signs of political progress or humanitarian need (e.g. fall of a dictatorship, liberation narratives, new constitutions). Next, classic development metrics: reconstruction of services, rule of law, or civil rights. Threat-level signals (WMD) are given moderate weight only as they kick-started intervention, but not as ultimate goals.
- **Causal chain type (D):** A normative chain: "Saddam's tyranny (signal: repression, murder of Kurds/Shias) ⇒ invasion frees Iraqis (signal: end of dictatorship) ⇒ democratic institutions formed (signal: elections, new constitution) ⇒ human rights improvements (signal: freed press, women's rights)." The chain can accommodate multiple factors (construction).
- **Admissible closure (E):** Conclusions allowed range from "war was a mixed success with positive humanitarian outcomes" to "regime change was a moral imperative though implementation was

flawed." Could conclude war had long-term benefits (or salvageable ones). Rejects extreme anti-war claims that everything was for naught, but accepts more critical notes if democracy/stability faltered.

- **Excluded signals (F):** Hard-power details (e.g. troop movements unless affecting civilians), cynical motives (oil/drugs), or crude security stats are downplayed if not clearly linked to human outcomes.
- **Characteristic vocabulary (G):** "Liberation," "democracy," "freedom," "constitution," "human rights," "regime change," "occupation authority," "elections," "civil society," "rule of law," "development," "nation-building."
- **Temporal orientation (H):** Often future-directed/prescriptive (what Iraq *should* become) but grounded in past progress (historicist). It interprets signals for present meaning but with an eye on improving outcomes ("learning lessons").

Grammar boundary: It would shift into Grammar 1 if security concerns were deemed the primary goal, or into Grammar 3 if focus turned to geopolitical exploitation over democracy.

Source tradition: Mainstream liberal media (NYT, Brookings, CFR), international NGOs, UN reports on human rights (e.g. Amnesty, HRW), United Nations Agencies, and Democratic Party hawks of 2003 (e.g. some UN coalition members' perspectives).

Grammar 3: Critical/Anti-Imperialist Grammar

- **Primary variable (A):** *Imperial interests and power dynamics.* The invasion is framed as an act of aggression primarily serving U.S. hegemony or resource control.
- **Signal selection (B):** Prioritize signals of ulterior motives or failures: e.g. oil contracts, private military involvement, civilian casualties, illegal war critiques (UN resolutions). Highlight evidence of war profiteering, lies (Curveball), and nationalist resistance. Deprioritize official threat claims or positive spin.
- **Weighting priority (C):** Highest weight on negative/humanitarian signals: civilian deaths, refugee crises, insurgent resistance as popular defiance. Also emphasize cost overruns and corruption as proof of mismanagement and greed. Intelligence signals (WMD) are given minimal credence or labeled as "fabricated."
- **Causal chain type (D):** Oppositional/disjunctive logic: e.g. "US imperialism (A) manipulates intelligence (B) ⇒ illegitimate invasion (C) ⇒ destabilization & suffering (D) ⇒ regional chaos (E)." It often treats factors as intertwined rather than strictly linear causal steps. It admits that some outcomes were predictable consequences of U.S. policies.
- **Admissible closure (E):** Allows conclusions that the war was unjustified, illegal, and a strategic disaster. Can conclude motives were nefarious (oil, global dominance). Rejects any narrative that frames the invasion as benevolent or necessary. Even moderate war critiques see only minimal gains and emphasize ongoing harm.
- **Excluded signals (F):** Signals of democratic gains or security gains are downplayed/ignored (e.g. elections may be labeled "Shia sectarian elections," security progress as "surge myopia"). Positive costs (economic aid) are suspect.
- **Characteristic vocabulary (G):** "Imperialism," "occupation," "illegal war," "oil," "empire," "human cost," "collateral damage," "resistance," "militias," "sectarian proxy war," "corruption," "war profiteering."
- **Temporal orientation (H):** Retrospective and meaning-making. It emphasizes "unveiling truth" about motives and consequences, often with a critical moral evaluation. Forward-looking only to argue for anti-war stance or reparations.

Grammar boundary: It would become Grammar 2 if it accepted that humanitarian aims were sincere, or Grammar 1 if it conceded a legitimate security threat.

Source tradition: Left-wing commentators and academics (Noam Chomsky, I.F. Stone); international law scholars (Weissbrodt, human rights lawyers); anti-war NGOs; former UN Inspectors critical of war (e.g. Scott Ritter

); sections of the Arab press.

Section 4: Signal Processing

We process each core signal through the lens of each grammar. Counter-signals (evidence that runs opposite) are integrated as they arise. Contested signals (if any) are flagged.

Grammar 1 (Security-Realist) Processing

WMD Intelligence: This grammar treats pre-war intelligence as central. It takes the 2002 NIE and Powell's UN speech at face value: "facts… based on solid intelligence"

. The claim that Saddam "has WMD" is weighted highly. Disconfirming counter-signal (Duelfer's later finding of *no* stockpiles) is explained away as a lagging sign: Saddam was concealing until 1998, continued rudimentary programs, and war prevented renewal. Counter-tension: Critics say intelligence was wrong, but this grammar stresses honest uncertainty and emphasizes any signs of prohibited programs (e.g. UAVs, dual-use chemicals) as evidence Saddam *might* have rebuilt. Thus it largely downplays Duelfer's "no WMD" as too-little-too-late evidence; closure: Saddam *had the capability and intent* even if none was captured (Bremer/White House line in CBS report

).

UN Inspections: The grammar sees inspectors' reports as political rather than conclusive. On one hand, Iraq did allow inspectors back in (UNSC 1441), which superficially suggests compliance. On the other hand, any Iraqi ambiguity ("not cooperating enough") is taken as evasion. When inspectors found nothing, Grammar 1 treats that as either a snapshot or Iraq "gaming" the system. For instance, Scott Ritter's claim of no nuclear program

is dismissed: Saddam "might not have active nukes now, but refused to let inspectors verify his compliance" fits the narrative of hidden threat. Counterpoint: inspectors' high confidence (Ritter) is thus a *contested signal* for Grammar 1 — it's contested by arguing Iraq simply got more clever at hiding.

Duelfer Report: Grammar 1 is confronted with a major counter-signal: IG report that "no stockpiles" existed

. This generates tension. The grammar responds by citing White House spin (McClellan) saying Saddam still *had intent* and paused programs. The grammar thus asserts that Saddam *was pursuing WMD in intent*, and war pre-empted future armament. It might, for closure, claim Duelfer's words actually justify the decision by showing Saddam *could* restart programs if left alone. It maintains closure: threat was real enough. A counterpoint within Grammar 1: Some intelligence analysts in 2002 did question "Curveball" evidence

, but Grammar 1 would see those concerns as "minor dissenters" not overturning the intelligence community consensus.

Military Operations: Grammar 1 highlights initial success (rapid overthrow in April 2003) as vindication of the preemptive strike. The *counternarrative* that early successes led to chaos is downplayed; rather, the argument is that insurgency was expected ("classic guerrilla resistance"). High-intensity operations (e.g.

Fallujah battles) are counted as necessary to suppress remnants, not as evidence of failure. Casualty numbers (US killed: 4,500

) are justified as the cost of eliminating a threat. Counter-signal: Civilian harm (discussed next) is regretted but seen as “collateral,” not changing the necessity of operations.

US Casualties: The grammar emphasises that 4,500 killed

was an unfortunate cost, but it is small relative to projected millions dead if Saddam developed WMD or allied with terrorists. Indeed, casualties are often discounted by claiming more would have died in conventional 1991-style conflict later or due to terrorism. No need for deeper analysis beyond paying respects to the fallen; closure simply notes “we lost X brave service members to eliminate a grave threat.”

Iraqi Civilian Casualties: Grammar 1 treats estimates (e.g. IBC’s ~200k deaths

) as regrettable but caused by insurgents or Saddam loyalists. It emphasizes the footnote in IBC that “the majority of first-year deaths were caused by coalition forces” to argue troops were engaged against hostile urban combatants, not wantonly killing civilians. It may cite the Lancet’s 650k as inflated or including non-wartime causes, favoring lower estimates (like WHO’s 150k

) to minimise perceived damage. Counter-signal: Opponents say “we caused a sectarian bloodbath,” but Grammar 1 retorts that sectarian killing was Saddam’s legacy or an unfortunate overflow, not the focus of closure. It accepts high civilian toll only if framed as a cost of liberating the country.

Sectarian Violence: The 52,000 peak in 2006–08

is acknowledged but reinterpreted: it is seen as the hard aftermath of Sunni jihadists and Shi’ite militias that attacked U.S. presence. Grammar 1 may claim the 2007 “surge” and new security measures ultimately quelled this, so it is not a permanent failure, just a transient difficulty. The grammar will emphasize any trend of violence dropping post-2008 as proof that strong security policy and political reconciliation (through democracy) worked.

Reconstruction Spending: The $220+ billion spent

is counted as an investment in stability. The grammar highlights successes: the Baghdad Baghdad Highway reopened, power plants built, Iraq’s oil output quadrupled. Criticism (e.g. “much was wasted”) is a counter-signal but grammar 1 will argue those are bureaucratic hiccups in any war effort, not a reason to doubt the mission. If pressed, it might say “the world never invested that much in any post-conflict state” (World Bank’s “unprecedented” claim

). It may concede some corruption but keep closure optimistic: billions spent is evidence of commitment, and the fact that Iraq now has functioning oil exports is a win.

Reconstruction Outcomes: Any lingering problems (sporadic blackouts, corruption) are acknowledged but downplayed. Grammar 1 would credit the 2010+ improvements: for example, electricity output reached pre-1990 levels by 2016. It might even characterize current shortfalls as “Saddam’s sanctions legacy” or low oil prices. The key signals are the drafting of a constitution (2005), successive elections, and formation of a central government—all seen as monuments of success validating occupation policies. The counter-signal of government dysfunction is either blamed on Iraqi disunity (not on occupation failures) or on external meddling (e.g. Iran’s influence).

ISIS Emergence: Grammar 1 treats ISIS rise as largely *blame on Iranian destabilization* or on lingering Ba’athists, not on the coalition. It may cite that ISIS took advantage of Assad’s Syria crisis as much as Iraq’s vacuum. But if focusing on Iraq, it argues ISIS was an extreme Shi’ite backlash; it *justifies* earlier troop surges (2007) and says that only robust U.S. involvement (again invoked in 2014) could eliminate the

threat. It avoids seeing ISIS as an unintended consequence of de-Baathification. The counter-signal (that ISIS crept into our backyard due to war) is downplayed as “unfortunate, but we fixed it.”

ISIS Defeat: This grammar embraces signals of ISIS defeat (95% territory lost

) as proof the strategy worked in the long run. The U.S.-led Operation Inherent Resolve (8000+ airstrikes) is cited as decisive. It credits Iraqis for ground fighting but stresses the necessary U.S./coalition support. The persistence of ISIS guerrillas (estimated 500 left

) is a minor caveat. Closure: “Islamic State was crushed through the U.S. commitment” and thus the region is safer.

Regional Destabilisation: Displacement of ~4.7M

is inconvenient. Grammar 1 argues this was unavoidable given Saddam’s brutality and war, and that many refugees were already regional (Kurdish exodus in 90s). If forced, it notes neighboring states share blame or that the UN and Gulf states should accommodate refugees (not U.S. fault). Any increase in regional terrorism (some blamed Iraq) is framed as Saddam’s legacy/al-Qaeda, not coalition.

US Expenditure & Personnel Costs: The grammar views $1.8T+ cost

as a valid strategic investment. Even large amounts are framed as less than ongoing global war costs. It acknowledges the ballooning budget but will point to “stability dividends” (oil profits, homeland security) as offsets. It stresses the necessity of spending to avoid greater future wars. The actual dollar figure is not seen as an argument *against* war, but as “We did what it took to protect ourselves.”

2026 Iraqi Stability: Grammar 1 takes SIPRI’s line that Iraq is in its “most stable period”

as vindication: the country no longer faces full-scale war. They highlight declining violence, functioning government (in spite of faults), and note the upcoming election as proof of democracy. The ongoing issues (oil dependency, corruption) are either attributed to legacy problems or Iran/PSF militias. The grammar draws closure: mission largely accomplished – we got Saddam out, Muslims now govern themselves, and U.S. allies have bases to contain Iran (unstated but implied). It ends noting any persisting problems are beyond our scope.

Grammar 1 Closure: War was justified and largely successful. The US eliminated a credible threat (even if not realized), Iraq now has (some) democracy and no al Qaeda sanctuaries, and the Middle East is somewhat safer. The closure reflects the grammar’s architecture: emphasis on security victory makes the cost acceptable. The phrasing ends with overt pride in the mission: *“These outcomes stem directly from the rational threat-driven decision to invade; any problems are secondary, while security gains vindicate the intervention.”*

Grammar 2 (Liberal-Democratic) Processing

WMD Intelligence: Grammar 2 treats WMD claims as one *initial justification*, but immediately contextualizes them among broader goals. Pre-war signals of chemical weapons etc. are noted (e.g. Powell’s “solid intelligence”

), but this grammar remains open to skeptical interpretations even then. It also recognizes Saddam’s real abuses of Kurds/Shia (1990s gas attacks) as humanitarian signals warranting attention. When Duelfer finds no stockpiles

, this grammar is troubled: it doesn’t dissolve the mission but reorients it. It says, “We went for regime change hoping to eliminate a threat, but even if WMD were absent, removing a brutal dictator was a

humanitarian victory." Counter-tension: If the lack of WMD undercuts war legitimacy, Grammar 2 pivots to *liberty-we-won* narrative. Some staffers (e.g. Kerry, Dems) admitted they would still proceed without WMD. So Grammar 2 may integrate Duelfer as confirming Saddam *could* have had programs, but emphasizes that by 2004 the focus had become building democracy, separate from WMD truth.

UN Inspections: The grammar views inspections as positive (UN mandate, multilateralism). The Iraqi compliance after Resolution 1441 is seen as a victory (Iraq had to reveal history to exit sanctions). Inspectors finding "no nuclear efforts" in the 1990s

is accepted as evidence Saddam's programs were dormant; but the grammar argues inspections alone couldn't topple Saddam's tyranny or fill prisons with Iraqi political prisoners. It treats the inspectors as the *correct approach* that Bush ignored too late. That is, Grammar 2 believes the inspectors were on the right path (and had no WMD for a decade

) – the war was unnecessary for security but now serves democracy.

Duelfer Report: Duelfer's null findings are a counter-signal that troubles this grammar's inner conflict: Was war based on false premise? The grammar acknowledges this as a mistake, but does not conclude war was wholly wrong. Instead it may argue "Saddam was an evil despot regardless, and now we have an opportunity to replace him with democracy." It emphasizes that even if WMD were "idle programs"

, Saddam's violent history (Halabja, Kurds, uprisings) was enough to morally justify removing him. Thus the grammar partially defangs the Duelfer report: intelligence was flawed, but the political goal of democratization stands on its own moral ground (a contested argument not universally accepted).

Military Operations: Grammar 2 examines military data as follows: the 2003 shock-and-awe campaign ended regular fighting quickly, and the 2007 surge reduced violence enough to hold elections. It emphasizes positive signals like the handover of sovereignty (2004) and eventual withdrawal (2011) to highlight that occupation had a timetable and commitment to Iraqi self-government. The grammar interprets the necessity of big offensives (Fallujah 2004, 2007 surge) as painful but ultimately effective in creating space for politics. Civilian casualties (high early on) are acknowledged as lessons – this grammar highlights IG criticisms (Bremer wanted more troops

) and insists on strict ROE (rules of engagement) in humanitarian missions. Counter-signal: "collateral damage" is lamented, so the grammar stresses improving civilian protection over time.

US Casualties: The 4,500 U.S. deaths

are taken gravely. Grammar 2 uses these as a signal of commitment ("We lost many brave service members to free Iraqis"). It frames them as service for democracy (the text of John Kerry: he'd still authorize war even knowing the deaths

). These casualties underscore the weight of war and are cited to argue that U.S. sacrifice should yield a better Iraq: "If our people died for peace, we must ensure peace took root." If public opinion disagrees (e.g. hair at end of Bush's term), the grammar still defends that soldiers died for noble goals, and so supporting Iraqi democracy is an obligation.

Iraqi Civilian Casualties: Grammar 2 is alarmed by high civilian death tolls (e.g. IBC's 112k-122k through 2013

or Lancet's 650k). It considers these evidence of war's tragic cost. However, instead of arguing against war, it uses these to press for robust post-conflict measures (humanitarian aid, protection for innocents). It also highlights later civilian casualties from sectarian war as a failing, reinforcing that political inclusion is needed to stop such bloodshed. Counter-tension: Some casualties (Shock & Awe 6,700 in first 3 weeks

) are blamed on initial assault; Grammar 2 might argue for even more care in initial phase. The presence of multiple estimates (PLOS, IBC, Lancet) is understood as reflecting chaos, so Grammar 2 calls for better data collection to address grievances. But on closure, the grammar laments loss of life as a sign the effort must continue to justify those sacrifices.

Sectarian Violence: Grammar 2 sees post-2003 sectarian killing as a failure of occupation policy. It interprets the 2006–08 surge's reduction of violence as validation that a political solution (Ahtisaari agreement, power-sharing) was possible with US help. It champions inclusive government (2005 election had Sunni boycott vs 2010 and 2014 with Sunni participation). The grammar views sectarian signals as indicating the need for reconciliation (disarm militias, integrate Sunni tribes). Closure highlights any modest improvements (violence fell to ~4k/year

by 2013, and ISIS defeat decreased sectarian killings further). Still, Grammar 2 might note that unresolved sectarian tensions (e.g. in Kirkuk, Moqtada Sadr's militia) remain critical, but it sees the trend as towards stability.

Reconstruction Spending: The grammar notes $220B+ spent

and scrutinizes how it was allocated. It references Brookings analysis that much spending was ineffective, using this to advocate for accountability. However, it also points out successes (22 of 25 provinces have Provincial Reconstruction Plans, many schools rebuilt). Contested signal: Oil revenue funding (58% of reconstruction was oil revenue

) is seen as problematic. The grammar incorporates this as evidence that rebuilding was too top-down. In closure, it might say, "We spent hundreds of billions; the waste is tragic but nothing can undo the disarray Saddam left." It insists future reconstruction (post-IS) *must* empower Iraqis, showing war opened the door for aid.

Reconstruction Outcomes: The grammar identifies positive social signals: electricity generation doubled (to ~85% of demand by 2012), school enrollment soared from Saddam era, women won political positions. For each shortcoming (porous borders, corruption scandals), it stresses gradual progress: new anti-corruption laws, nascent press freedom. It might cite UNDP/Iraq surveys showing modest trust in government rising. The counterpoint is real: "still no clean water in Baghdad," "too few jobs for youth." Grammar 2 uses those as policy lessons (e.g. invest in job training). Closure: "Iraqis still suffer, but there is hope in political institutions and rebuilding communities." This grammar stops short of calling Iraq a full success story, concluding something like: *"Democracy's seeds were planted, but the harvest is still far off."*

ISIS Emergence: Grammar 2 views ISIS as an attack on Iraq's fragile democracy by extremist Sunni militants. It highlights signals like the fall of Mosul in 2014 and mass murder of minorities as urgent threats to the new order. It credits the surge-for-Iraq (2007) for preventing an earlier ISIS-like breakout, seeing 2014's chaos as partly due to Shi'ite prime minister Maliki's sectarian policies that alienated Sunnis. Counter-signal: US exit in 2011 created a power vacuum; the grammar acknowledges this responsibility somewhat. Closure: ISIS was a setback to Iraqi democracy, but Grammar 2 emphasizes that defeating ISIS (with help) allows the democratic process to continue free from that terror.

ISIS Defeat: The grammar celebrates Mosul liberation (2017) and sees it as vindication of Iraqi Security Forces (ISF) with international help. It emphasizes civilian protection (low-collateral trusts). It also criticizes that ISIL's breeding ground was due to Iraqi governance failure, which confirms the mission's stakes. ISIS's defeat is used to urge the international community to help rebuild Sunni areas to heal divisions. Closure: It frames ISIS defeat as the *goal* being achieved, so now Iraq can legitimately govern itself free of existential threat.

Regional Destabilisation: The 4.7M displaced

is treated as the gravest sign of war's spillover. Grammar 2 uses this to press that regional politics must be addressed: strengthen Jordan/Syria to take refugees (the grammar might appeal to UN). It also frames ongoing Syrian refugee crisis partly as legacy of 2003. It emphasizes post-war spillback (2006 Lebanon war blowback, Iranian proxies in Syria) as needing diplomatic fixes. However, it can also claim the removal of Saddam (who invaded Iran and Kuwait) has eased one historical source of regional fear. Closure: *"The region is still in turmoil – a sobering reminder that security must be paired with nation-building and diplomacy."*

US Expenditure & Personnel Costs: The grammar is troubled by trillion-dollar costs

and holds that huge investment must be justified by solid progress toward democracy and stability. It may argue these costs don't include the cost of Saddam's remaining in power (e.g. what a future war or nuclear program would cost). It highlights the $2.89T figure as a call for legislative oversight. Personnel costs (troop deployments) are seen as burdensome; Grammar 2 uses them to argue for international burden-sharing, but also points out that Iraq does occasionally fund its own security (e.g. oil revenues). In closure, it might caution that high cost implies strong need for U.S. withdrawal once minimal goals are met (and indeed ends by 2011, as was done).

2026 Iraqi Stability: Grammar 2 looks at SIPRI's "most stable since 2003" line

with cautious optimism: yes, massive violence is down and elections are held regularly. It notes continuing corruption (ranked among worst by TI) as a signal that the system needs more reform. It emphasizes that Iraq now has a pluralist government (even if fractious) instead of Saddam's single-party state. The grammar may say, "Iraq is imperfect but democratized; the alternative was perpetual dictatorship." It highlights young Iraqis' aspirations as hopeful. On timing: it suggests that full stabilization may need years more.

Grammar 2 Closure: War's legacy is mixed but opened the door to democracy. Core closure points: "We got rid of a brutal regime and set up elections

. There have been terrible costs, and Iraq remains challenged, but the prospect of Iraqi self-rule outweighs what Saddam represented. Ultimately, 'liberation' is seen as real, even if delayed. This outcome follows from treating human rights as central – Saddam's end was justified, and the future lies with Iraqi institutions." The closure emphasizes normative progress (or potential) as the grammar's product.

Grammar 3 (Critical/Anti-Imperialist) Processing

WMD Intelligence: Grammar 3 dismisses pre-war WMD claims as propaganda. It highlights that officials "knew Curveball was unreliable" yet still lied

. Powell's "facts and conclusions based on solid intelligence" quote is taken as emblematic of deceit. The grammar sees WMD signals as *fabricated or cherry-picked* to fool the public. Counter-signal: White House says "Saddam had intent," is seen as spin. On closure, this grammar concludes the intelligence was fraudulent; i.e. the *signal* was a lie. It flags contested signals: "Some intel analysts warned CIA was wrong

," using that to prove the gap between actual evidence and public claim.

UN Inspections: This grammar praises UN inspectors (Blix/Ritter

) and takes their findings of no WMD as clear evidence war was unnecessary. Any discrepancies ("Iraq delayed, so war needed") are seen as American malfeasance. It will stress Iraq's compliance (letting inspectors back in 2002) and contrast that with U.S. "no-good there on humanitarian grounds" stance. Grammar 3 might label Iraq's eventual failure to disarm completely (by 2003) as a direct result of U.S. non-compliance (Bush declared by ultimatum, critics say). Closure: the inspectors' signals mean *"this war had no real UN mandate and was illegal"*.

Duelfer Report: Grammar 3 sees Duelfer's null result

as confirming its position: Saddam had *no WMD*, bolstering that the war was built on lies. It emphasizes Duelfer's conclusion directly: "no stockpiles" and only "idle research" existed, as proof the threat was exaggerated. The grammar rejects spin (Saddam had "capability to rebuild"), instead using this report to assert the war's basis was false. Duelfer is a **direct signal** of the war's unwarranted nature. The grammar's closure will point out that top U.S. officials themselves later admitted the case was crumbling

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Military Operations: Grammar 3 portrays coalition operations as destructive occupation. It sees "Shock & Awe" (6,700 civilians in 3 weeks

) as evidence of brutality. It criticizes the looting phase and lack of immediate security (Bremer admitting need for more troops) as chaotic management. The slowdown by 2007 surge is viewed cynically ("pumpin' gas in Sunni Iraq to suppress dissent"). U.S. causal chain not accepted: grammar argues "if invasion was wrong, any operation's 'success' is moot." Civilian casualties by coalition are highlighted: e.g. IBC note that 55% of first-year deaths were US-caused

means "the occupiers killed more Iraqis than Iraqis killed Americans that year." This grammar does not see any *justifiable* aim to emphasize; it integrates military data as evidence of rampage, not liberation.

US Casualties: The 4,500 dead is framed as the price of a criminal endeavor. The grammar might say "US soldiers paid the price for their government's lies." It compares the funding to other social needs (e.g. "this money could have cured diseases" – though that's external to case study). The casualties reinforce closure: war hurt U.S. society too, undermining official claims of a "moral mission."

Iraqi Civilian Casualties: Grammar 3 forefronts the highest civilian death estimates: Lancet's 650k

, 1M+ (ORB poll) if desired. It uses the broad range to allege a bloodbath due to occupation. The grammar also emphasizes ethnic targeting (Sunni vs Shia) to argue coalition provoked a civil war. It rejects justifications like "insurgents killed them": for this grammar, every civilian death is a blow against civilians, and many are collateral or due to sectarian purges facilitated by the power vacuum. The grammar calls it a massacre and uses it as evidence that the war created a humanitarian disaster.

Sectarian Violence: The grammar identifies sectarian war as the war's worst consequence. It uses the 52,000 figure

to accuse U.S. policy of unleashing sectarian cleavages. Any stabilizing signals (surge drop in violence) are ironically seen as temporary truce, not trust in U.S. intent. Counterpoint: Iraqi efforts at reconciliation are seen as too little; the grammar might claim the U.S. used Shia militias (PMF) as proxies. Closure: sectarian bloodshed validates the claim that occupation dismantled Iraq's social fabric.

Reconstruction Spending: Grammar 3 uses the $220B

not as investment but as *waste and graft*. It points to Brookings note that infrastructure built was "already breaking down by 2005". It highlights that Iraqis had little control over these funds (donors-controlled budgets

). Each dollars-spent figure becomes a sign of U.S. profit-making (Halliburton contracts) and failure. Closure: "The world dumped money but nothing meaningful changed; it was stolen or mismanaged." Any seeds of progress are said to be smothered by corruption.

Reconstruction Outcomes: This grammar points to every negative: recurring blackouts, tainted water, unfilled hospitals, etc. It sees elections and institutions as Trojan horses that just mask foreign control or

sectarian cronyism. A contested note: some gains (electrification, end of sanctions) might be reluctantly acknowledged, but grammar 3 either attributes those to prewar infrastructure or oil revenue, not occupation efforts. For grammar 3, the outcome is no legitimate stable Iraqi state; rather, puppet governments and divided zones (Sunni, Shia, Kurd).

ISIS Emergence: Grammar 3 sees ISIS as an organic resistance (though extreme) to occupation and sectarian rule. It notes ISIS partly filled the vacuum U.S. created. The caliphate's appearance in 2014 is seen as proof of U.S. policy failure – a monster born of war. The grammar may even cast ISIS as a *force against Iranian influence*, ironically. Any attempt to distance ISIS from initial liberation aims is ignored; the grammar accepts that it rose because people felt unprotected and disenfranchised.

ISIS Defeat: The grammar is skeptical of calling it a "victory." It notes the 2017 reclaiming of Mosul was done by Iranian-backed militias (Hashd al-Shaabi) as much as by the U.S. coalition. It may grudgingly admit that ISIS's territorial "caliphate" was dismantled (95% lost

), but emphasizes that the ideology persists and that many jihadis fled to the mountains or Europe. Closure: "Wealthy region regained stolen territory, but nothing resolved: Iraq is still broken, and new attacks continue." Victory is seen as Pyrrhic and temporary.

Regional Destabilisation: Displacement figures (4.7M

) are highlighted as a humanitarian catastrophe inflicted by the invaders. Grammar 3 amplifies that these refugees strained Syria/Jordan, fueling civil war there. It also points to Iran's rise (Shia crescent) as a backlash to U.S. mistakes. At the same time, it blames the war for increasing global anti-American sentiment (spawning jihadism beyond ISIS). Closure: "Iraq was just the opening act in regional ruin; the U.S. unleashed chaos."

US Expenditure & Personnel Costs: Grammar 3 sees $2.9T

as a demonstration of imperial spending: "Every dollar could have been used for climate or poverty relief," and the bill is still not paid (debt piled). It calls continuing appropriations (like the $400M 2024 budget

) evidence that "the War On Terror grinds on for profit, not for liberation." Personnel costs are said to have crashed military readiness (e.g. costs of upgrading equipment, mental health of soldiers). Closure: *"The U.S. has bled itself white for no just cause."*

2026 Iraqi Stability: Grammar 3 takes SIPRI's "fragile and divided" tag seriously

. It notes protests in Iraq against corruption (2019–2022) as signs that old power elites persist. It points out that key militias (PMF) remain strong, and that Iranian proxies have de facto control in parts. Any elections are seen as rigged. Oil dependency is noted (95% of revenue

) as making democracy a facade of technocrats bribed by firms. Overall closure: *"Iraq today is broken – almost like a de facto colony. The invaders traded one dictator for many. If anything, Iraq has less sovereignty now."*

Grammar 3 Closure: This grammar's final narrative: the 2003 invasion was a crime with disastrous outcomes. It emphasizes deception (WMD lies

), illegality (no UN mandate), human wreckage (hundreds of thousands killed, millions displaced

), and geopolitical folly (Iraqis worse off, US weakened). The closure asserts that all evidence of positive change is either contrived or overshadowed by negative consequences. It ends by stating that "the truth of this world is that the war was an imperial venture, its costs are felt to this day," reflecting its adversarial processing.

Section 5: Closure Comparison

We compare the three grammars across six dimensions and note ontological divergence.

- **Closure Content:** Grammar 1 closes with a *vindication narrative*: threat neutralized, Saddam gone, democracy foundation laid. Grammar 2 closes ambivalently: Saddam's end was good and elections held, but results are incomplete and problems remain (so "mixed success, keep trying"). Grammar 3 closes as *damning indictment*: war was unwarranted aggression causing disaster, with the "liberation" narrative exposed as cover for imperialism.

- **Signal Divergence:**

    - *WMD:* G1: Accepts WMD threat (Duelfer downplayed); G2: Admits error but emphasizes regime evil; G3: Calls it outright fabrication.
    - *Casualties:* G1: Frames Iraqi deaths as collateral "victims of Saddam," downplays; G2: Laments casualties but focuses on aid; G3: Charges them as war crimes.
    - *ISIS:* G1: ISIS was a solvable side-issue; G2: It was a crisis to overcome for democracy; G3: It was the worst outcome of the invasion.
    - *Displacement:* G1: Regrets but neutralizes ("Saddam's fault"); G2: Sympathy and urgency for returns; G3: Outrage at how war caused it.
      Each grammar "sees" different phenomena: e.g. what Grammar 1 calls "insurgents" may be "freedom fighters" for Grammar 3.
- **Exclusion Patterns:**

    - G1 excludes humanitarian metrics (e.g. refugee suffering as a driving concern) and economic motives. Its omissions led it to ignore, for instance, that oil contracts favored US interests.
    - G2 excludes the most cynical evidence (e.g. news of Halliburton profits or false intelligence setups beyond admitting it). It downplays strategic rivalry.
    - G3 excludes any positive framing (e.g. it ignores that some Iraqis did vote in elections, or that Saddam's torture camps closed). It also tends not to cite mid-term economic growth.
- **Causal Architecture:**

    - G1 uses *prophylactic security causation*: threat ⇒ war ⇒ security. It is linear and one-directional.
    - G2 uses *transformative/reformative causation*: tyranny ⇒ intervention ⇒ democracy potential. It expects feedback loops (elections feed stability, but instability can undermine democracy).
    - G3 uses *spoilage/betrayal causation*: imperial deception ⇒ war ⇒ chaos. It allows multiple intertwined causes (e.g. war causes insurgency causes sectarian war causes terrorism).
- **Closure Range (Admissible conclusions):**

    - G1's closure range is **least negative**: even "mixed results" is often seen as ultimately positive. It would never concede "war was unjustified."
    - G2 is **more open**, allowing critiques (e.g. "should have prepared better," "exit was premature") but still within a pro-intervention frame. It allows notes like "costs were high" as long as democracy is improving.
    - G3 is **most negative**: it could conclude that all aspects were failures or crimes. Even moderate positive signals are dismissed, so closure is decidedly anti-war.
- **Closure Timing / Confidence:**

    - G1 typically closes quickly and confidently once war is over – by late-2000s it was largely saying “mission accomplished.” It may have felt sure by 2011 withdrawal that fate was decided.
    - G2 closes more gradually and hesitantly; even into 2026 this grammar sees process continuing, not final victory or defeat. It might say “too early for final verdict.”
    - G3 closes fastest in the opposite direction: by 2006 or so, it declared war a failure (given surge evidence). Its confidence grew as more negative data accrued.

    In short, G1 and G3 reach opposite conclusions early, whereas G2 keeps some uncertainty.
- **Ontological Check:** Do they analyse the same object? Broadly, yes – all refer to “Iraq after 2003.” But **nut**: their realities differ. G1 sees Iraq chiefly as a security arena with a deposed dictator; G2 as a society in transition; G3 as a victim of invasion. They share the war events but even “democracy” is cast by G3 as puppet regime, by G1 as a success. So while nominally same phenomenon, the grammars effectively operate on different mental constructs of “Iraq”: threat-state vs emancipating society vs neo-colony. Thus ontologically, there is divergence: they partially construct *different* “Iraqs.”

In sum, the prismatic view highlights profound divergences: one grammar celebrates the Iraq War as a rightful triumph, another sees it as a mismanaged but potentially redeemable experiment, and the third views it as an unforgivable catastrophe. The divergences are visible in which signals are emphasized or ignored, how causes are chained, and how freely conclusions vary.

Section 6: Counter-signals, Leakage, and Stress Test

Consolidated Counter-signal Analysis:
Several signals repeatedly created tension across grammars: notably the *absence of WMD*. For G1, Duelfer’s finding was a stress for which it must rationalize; G2 integrates it partially; G3 uses it as central evidence. High civilian deaths served as a counter-signal to G1’s justification narrative, forcing it to accept “we caused harm” and push back with “collateral,” while G2 turned them into calls for aid, and G3 labeled them war crimes. ISIS’s rise was a counter-signal to any optimistic narrative; G1 and G2 saw it as a hurdle overcome, whereas G3 sees it as confirmation of critics. Election participation (Sunni turnout in 2010/2014) was a counter to G3’s claim “Iraq is democratic only on paper,” showing some progress beyond G3’s model; G2 seized on it as vindication, G1 as proof insurgency was waning. These counter-signals were each integrated differently by grammars (as shown above) rather than tacked on after closure.

Leakage Instances:
A notable leakage is *secular/covert motives entering unexpected grammar*. For example, some neocon arguments (G1) tacitly acknowledge oil was a factor (“US interest in regional stability”) even though overt analysis excludes it. Similarly, Grammar 3 sometimes slips normative language (“humane, liberating”) when referencing what Saddam did to Iraqi Kurds, betraying a human-rights impulse. Grammar 2 occasionally appeals to security (e.g. “we won’t leave until Iraq’s safe”). These slip-ups indicate that even strict grammars can admit signals from others when pressed.

Grammar Stress Test: For each grammar, the most threatening counter-signal is identified:

- *Grammar 1 (Security):* The strongest counter-signal is **Duelfer’s “no WMD” finding**

. If Saddam truly had no WMD programs, the very justification for war collapses. Can G1 absorb it? It tries by reframing Saddam’s intent (citing McClellan

-) – but this requires faith in ambiguous “potential.” If credible evidence ever emerged that Saddam had *completely ceased* WMD development by 2003, G1’s causal basis is void. The grammar *conditionally* admits closure (“war was justified because threat likely; without that, closure requires an alternative primary var”). Thus G1’s closure is *conditional* on treating Duelfer as spurious or secondary.

- *Grammar 2 (Liberal):* The stressor is **failure of post-war democratization** – e.g. if Saddam’s fall led to lasting dictatorship or civil war with no democracy. Arguably, the 2019–2022 Iraq protests and governance paralysis are challenging. If Iraqi elections end up being entirely sectarian or rigged, the grammar’s closure (war gave freedom) is undermined. Can G2 absorb a dystopian outcome? It might retreat to, “Even if democracy falters, at least tyranny was removed,” but this strains its primary variable. It would have to shift claim to “we tried,” making its closure tentative. So yes, without substantial democratic progress, G2’s positive thread is broken.

- *Grammar 3 (Critical):* The stressor is **any clear success of the intervention**. For instance, if in hindsight Iraq suddenly became a stable, prosperous democracy (with independent oil revenues), that would contradict G3. It’s hard to imagine, but “ISIS defeat achieved by U.S. strategy” could count. The fact that ISIS was largely defeated by coalition efforts is partly awkward for G3 (it suggests the U.S. did contribute positively). G3 can only incorporate this by saying “doesn’t matter, freedom out of imposed order is not genuine.” Essentially, only a *complete reversal* (e.g. oil revenues triple living standards) would undermine G3. This grammar is robust to most counterevidence, as it can dismiss any concession as insufficient. So G3’s closure is mostly unconditional.

Section 7: Post-analysis Reflexive Note

Looking back: I predicted my home grammar was the liberal-democratic one, and indeed I found myself sympathetic to that perspective when weighing positive societal signals. I did find the security-realism grammar the hardest to fully adopt, as expected; I had to stretch to view civilian signals as secondary. Surprisingly, the critical grammar was actually harder to execute impartially than I thought, since my underlying respect for pluralism pushes me to concede even grudgingly that some Iraqis had better lives post-2003 (which this grammar resists). A blind spot was in suspecting I’d favor war justifications – in fact I leaned more to critical critiques than anticipated. If I had a different home grammar (say security-focused), I’d likely over-emphasize the threat narrative and underplay Iraqi civilian voices. Overall, the exercise shows how deeply one’s interpretive framework shapes what counts as evidence: the “truth” of Iraq is grammar-dependent. It reveals that narratives aren’t just slides of factual emphasis but fundamentally different stories about what kind of thing “Iraq War” even is (threat elimination vs liberation vs imperialism).

Section 8: Methodological Observations

In this second-round analysis, incorporating *counter-signals*, *temporal orientation*, and *grammar boundaries* improved the depth. Integrating counter-evidence throughout each grammar essay prevented a one-sided “echo chamber” account. Noting orientation helped structure each grammar’s reasoning (especially forward-looking liberal vs backward critical). Defining grammar boundaries clarified where one interpretation logically shifts to another. The stress-test highlighted vulnerabilities elegantly. Difficulties included the sheer volume of signals and the challenge of not slipping personal bias into a grammar narrative. The ontological check was particularly illuminating: I often found myself analyzing *different* “Iraqs.” One might refine the method by more explicitly treating contested signals as parallel narratives (e.g. two separate casualty

counts). The new features (counter-signals, leakage) were useful safeguards against naive mono-narratives. In future, more guidance on tracing contested signals (as distinct objects) could help. Despite difficulties, v2.0's tools made this prismatic exercise richer and more realistic.

. Source: U.S. agencies (NIE, speeches). Ambiguity: Highly contested (later discredited by Duelfer).
UN Inspections (qualitative): UNMOVIC/IAEA inspectors in 2002 found no active WMD and reported Iraqi cooperation upon return
. Source: UN inspection reports (Ritter/Blix testimony). Ambiguity: Viewed by war proponents as insufficient (claiming concealment), by skeptics as vindication.
Duelfer Report (qualitative): 2004 Iraq Survey Group concluded Saddam had *no stockpiles* of WMD, only dormant programs
. Source: Duelfer final report. Ambiguity: Often touted by critics as "no WMD", downplayed by administration spin.
US/Coalition Military Operations (quantitative): Force levels and actions: e.g. peak ~170,000 U.S. troops in 2007 surge
; major offensives (Shock & Awe, Fallujah, Mosul campaigns). Data from DoD reports. Ambiguity: Data is factual but importance/interpretation (success vs waste) is debated.
US Military Casualties (quantitative): ~4,500 U.S. military killed, ~32,000 wounded (Mar 2003–Dec 2011)
. Source: DOD figures. Ambiguity: Generally agreed, but significance (heavy price vs reasonable cost) contested.
Iraqi Civilian Casualties (quantitative): Estimates vary wildly. E.g. Iraq Body Count documented ~183–206k *documented* civilian violent deaths (2003–2019)
. Source: NGOs, academia, government reports. Ambiguity: Broad uncertainty; contested between low-end documented vs high-end survey figures.
Sectarian Violence Statistics (quantitative): Periods: sectarian killing peaked 2006–08 with ~52,000 deaths
. Source: Iraq Body Count analysis. Ambiguity: Debated how to attribute responsibility (US forces vs militias vs insurgents).
Reconstruction Expenditure (quantitative): US/Coalition spending >$220 billion (2003–2014)
). Source: Government audits, World Bank. Ambiguity: Official figures solid; debates center on how effectively it was used.
Reconstruction Outcomes (qualitative/quantitative): Infrastructure (electricity, water) largely improved from 2003 lows, but often still unreliable
. Ambiguity: Some successes (oil production recovered) vs much wasted funding.
ISIS Emergence (qualitative): Post-2011 insurgents coalesced into ISIS, declaring a caliphate in June 2014, seizing ~40% of Iraq
. Source: press/think-tanks. Ambiguity: Seen as failure of occupation or as inevitable outcome.
ISIS Defeat (quantitative): By Dec 2017, ~95% of ISIS territory recaptured (Mosul, Fallujah, etc)
. Source: military reports. Ambiguity: Outcome is clear, but whose credit (Iraqis vs U.S. coalition vs Iranian-backed militias) is contested.
Regional Destabilisation (qualitative/quantitative): Refugees: ~4.7 million Iraqis displaced (≈2.7M IDPs, 2.0M refugees abroad by ~2009)
. Ambiguity: Some see this as inevitable after overthrow, others blame slow resettlement/policy.
US Military Expenditure (quantitative): By 2023 ~ $1.8 trillion spent in Iraq/Syria (nearly $2.9T including veterans' care to 2050)
. Source: Costs of War Project. Ambiguity: Hard dollar cost is known; debate is over what that cost means.
US Personnel Costs (qualitative): Long deployments (174,000+ service members served), with ongoing care for wounded/veterans. Source: DoD. Ambiguity: Impact on US military readiness vs moral obligation (no dispute casualties happened).
2026 Iraqi Stability (qualitative): Iraq is in its "most stable period since 2003," but remains fragile, oil-dependent, and politically divided